For adults only, with a finishing kick of gin, this dramatic-looking dark pink dish carries distinct eastern European flavors of dill, caraway, and sour cream.

beet and gin soup

SERVES 4–6 **PREP** 10 MINS **COOK** 50 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS WITHOUT THE GIN

2 stems of fresh parsley
1 bay leaf
2 large sprigs of fresh dill or fennel
2 tbsp sunflower oil
1 onion, chopped
½ tbsp caraway seeds
3 tbsp arborio rice
1½lb (650g) beets, peeled and grated
1 tbsp lemon juice
1 quart (1 liter) beef stock, chicken stock, or vegetable stock
salt and freshly ground black pepper
2 tbsp gin or vodka
sour cream or crème fraîche, to serve
chopped fresh dill or chives, to serve

1 Make a bouquet garni (see p24) using the parsley, bay leaf, and sprigs of dill or fennel. Heat the oil in a saucepan and cook the onion, caraway, and bouquet garni over low heat, covered, for 10 minutes.

2 Add the rice to the pan, and stir for about 1 minute to coat it in the juices. Add the beets and lemon juice (to set the color), and continue cooking, stirring constantly, for another 2–3 minutes.

3 Pour in the stock, season with salt and pepper, and bring to a boil. Simmer for 25–30 minutes, until both the beets and rice are tender. Remove and discard the bouquet garni. Add ½ cup of water to the pan.

4 Using a blender, process the soup until smooth, in batches if necessary. Return to the pan, adjust the seasoning, and stir in the gin. Reheat thoroughly, without letting the soup boil. Serve steaming hot, with a generous swirl of sour cream in each and a sprinkling of dill or chives.